Storyteller

A story distribution platform for the music industry

Production Plan

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CONFIDENTIAL

What We're Building

Storyteller is a story distribution platform for the music industry. Artists record short audio narratives about their songs, and Storyteller distributes those stories to streaming platforms as a new content type.

> **Think of it like DistroKid, but for the stories behind songs instead of the songs themselves.**

How It Works

1. **Record** — Artist records or uploads a story about their song
2. **Package** — Storyteller links it to the track and packages it with metadata
3. **Distribute** — Story assets are pushed to streaming platforms via API
4. **Listen** — Listener plays a song — the story plays first, then the track begins

Why This Matters

Streaming killed liner notes. Every song has a story — its inspiration, meaning, how it was made — but that context disappeared when music went digital. Spotify's "About the Song" feature shows text cards. Storyteller brings the stories back as **audio**, integrated into the listening experience.

Who Uses It

User	What They Do	How They Access It
Artists	Record, upload, and manage stories about their songs	Web app + Mobile app
Labels	Manage stories across their roster of artists	Web app
Streaming Platforms	Pull story assets and metadata for playback integration	Distribution API

Listeners never touch Storyteller. They experience stories through their existing streaming app.

What We're Building (v1)

Artist & Label Portal

Web app + Mobile app

- ✓ Artist sign-up and identity verification
- ✓ Browse catalog (tracks linked by ISRC)
- ✓ Bulk catalog import (CSV upload)
- ✓ Record a story directly in the app
- ✓ Upload pre-recorded story audio
- ✓ Link stories to specific tracks
- ✓ Verify, edit, replace, or delete stories
- ✓ Story status dashboard
- ✓ Notifications (distributed, flagged, etc.)

Backend Platform

Core services + Distribution API

- ✓ Story management (create, edit, version)
- ✓ Track-to-story mapping via ISRC
- ✓ Artist verification workflow
- ✓ Story prioritization engine
- ✓ Content moderation & review queue
- ✓ Distribution API for streaming partners
- ✓ Webhook notifications on changes
- ✓ Admin / ops dashboard
- ✓ Full audit trail for compliance

Designed For Future (Not Built in v1)

The architecture accommodates these — they plug in without rebuilding anything:

- ○ AI narrative generation
- ○ AI voice likeness narration
- ○ AI safety guardrails
- ○ Archival compilation from interviews
- ○ Lyrics validation engine
- ○ Instrumental crossfade
- ○ Analytics dashboard
- ○ Interactive storytelling

All future features are covered in the patent filing and expand the platform's value over time.

Infrastructure Cost

Infrastructure scales with the business. We start lean and add capacity as partnerships grow.

PHASE 1 — NOW

Build & Launch

~$50 /month

PaaS hosting, managed database, S3 storage. Single environment.

PHASE 2 — FIRST PARTNER

Production Ready

$300–800 /month

Staging + production, CDN for audio, monitoring. Platform depends on API.

PHASE 3 — SCALE

Multiple Partners

$1–2k /month

Auto-scaling, database replicas, global CDN. 99.9%+ uptime.

PHASE 4 — ENTERPRISE

Global Scale

$3–10k+ /month

Multi-region, SOC 2 / GDPR, 99.99% SLA. Funded by revenue.

Development Cost

Team

Role	Responsibility
1–2 Backend Developers	API, database, distribution service, business logic
1 Frontend / Mobile Developer	Web + mobile app (shared React / React Native codebase)
1 Designer (part-time)	UX for artist portal, recording flow, brand

Timeline

Wk 1–2	Wk 2–10	Wk 6–12	Wk 10–16	Wk 14–17
Tech Stack	Backend API + DB	Web App	Mobile App	Testing

Total to first usable product: ~3–4 months

Revenue Model

Storyteller generates revenue as the distribution layer for story content across the streaming industry.

Model	Description
Platform Licensing	Streaming platforms pay to access the story catalog (annual license per platform)
Per-Stream Royalty	Small fee per story play ($0.001 – $0.005 per stream)
Artist / Label Subscription	Monthly fee for premium features (analytics, priority support, bulk tools)
Content Licensing	Labels pay for AI story generation across their catalog (future)

Market context: Global music streaming is ~$40B/year with ~5 trillion annual streams. Even a fraction of a cent per story play at scale is significant. Platform licensing to 4 major services alone could be substantial.

IP Protection

Provisional Utility Patent (Draft Ready)

Title: "AI-Driven Storytelling System for Pre-Playback Narratives in Digital Media Streaming Platforms"

Inventors: Robert Riggs & David Knowlton

Coverage: 50+ claims covering pre-playback storytelling, AI voice likeness, archival compilation, lyrics validation, story prioritization, artist verification, skip controls, and cross-platform distribution

Filing cost: ~$75 – $150 (provisional)

Timeline: Provisional filing establishes priority date and provides 12 months to file the full non-provisional patent

Legal & Business Requirements

Items that must be addressed before or during development.

Legal Structure

- ✓ Form LLC (or appropriate entity)
- ✓ Ownership / equity agreement
- ✓ Define roles and decision authority
- ✓ File provisional patent ($75–150)

Content Policy

- ✓ Define allowed / prohibited content
- ✓ Moderation workflow (auto + manual)
- ✓ Appeals process for rejected content
- ✓ Content labeling (explicit, etc.)

Artist Rights & Consent

- ✓ Content licensing agreement
- ✓ Who owns uploaded stories?
- ✓ Distribution rights across platforms
- ✓ Revocation policy
- ✓ Voice likeness consent (for future AI)

Privacy

- ✓ Privacy policy for artist data
- ✓ GDPR compliance (EU artists)
- ✓ Data retention & deletion policies

Artist Onboarding

Artists must be verified before stories can be distributed. Three paths:

Method	How It Works
Label Invitation	Label manager invites artist by email. Label vouches for identity.
Distributor Linking	Artist connects existing DistroKid/TuneCore account to verify catalog.
Manual Review	Independent artists without a label submit for admin verification.

Artists can also bulk import their catalog via CSV upload (ISRC + title). Future: direct distributor API integration.

Go-to-Market

Start selling at v1. Don't wait for AI features.

Timeline to First Sale

Milestone	Target
File provisional patent	ASAP
Development starts	Week 2
v1 platform ready	~Month 4
First artists onboarded (label partner)	Month 4–5
20–50 songs with real stories on platform	Month 5
Start streaming platform conversations	**Month 5–6**

The Pitch

> **"Press play. Listen to this. Now imagine every song on your platform had this. Here's the API — it's one integration. We already have artists recording."**

Deferred features (AI generation, analytics, instrumental crossfade) are the **roadmap pitch** — "today it's artist-recorded, tomorrow we generate stories for your entire catalog automatically."

First Target Platforms

Priority	Platform	Why
1	**Spotify**	Largest platform, most feature-forward, precedent with Canvas/Storylines
2	**Apple Music**	Premium positioning, values artist relationships
3	**Amazon / YouTube Music**	Secondary targets, expand distribution reach

First Steps

A clear path from idea to working product.

1. **File the provisional patent** — Establishes priority date and IP protection. Cost: $75–150 at USPTO.
2. **Form legal entity** — LLC or equivalent. Ownership/equity agreement between founders.
3. **Finalize tech stack** — Confirm backend language/framework, mobile framework, and cloud provider.
4. **Hire developers** — 2–3 developers: backend + frontend/mobile. Freelance or agency.
5. **Build v1** — Artist portal (web + mobile), story management backend, distribution API. ~3–4 months.
6. **Onboard first artists** — Use the label partner's roster to populate the platform with real stories.
7. **Approach first streaming platform** — Demo real stories from real artists on a working platform.

Summary

WHAT
Story distribution platform for music streaming

HOW
Artists record → Storyteller distributes → Platforms play stories before tracks

V1 SCOPE
Artist portal (web + mobile), backend, distribution API, admin tools

INFRA COST
$50/mo now → $300–800/mo at first partner → $1–2k/mo at scale

DEV COST
$20k–80k depending on hiring approach (3–4 months)

PATENT
Provisional draft ready, $75–150 to file

FIRST ADVANTAGE
Label partner with interested artists — supply side is ready

GOAL
Real stories, real artists, working platform → approach streaming partners

Competitive Advantage

We already have what most startups spend months trying to get.

SUPPLY SIDE

A label partner with artists already interested in recording stories

DISTRIBUTION MODEL

Slots into how streaming platforms already work — no new behavior required

IP PROTECTION

Provisional patent with 50+ claims covering the full system

SCALABLE ARCHITECTURE

Designed to grow from first artists to full AI pipeline without rebuilding

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